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Book Author(s): NISHANT UPADHYAY

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INTRODUCTION

COLONIAL AND RACIAL ENTANGLEMENTS

For millennia, the Mississaugas of the New Credit, Anishinaabe, Chippewa, Haudenosaunee, Wendat, Métis peoples, and many other diverse Indigenous communities have lived on Treaty 13 territory, or what is commonly known in settler cartography as Toronto. It is also known as the Dish with One Spoon territory, which was named after the 1701 Treaty made between the Anishinaabe, Mississauga, and Haudenosaunee nations to share the territory and protect the land. The word “Toronto” originates from the Mohawk word “Tkarón:to,” which means “the place in the water where the trees are standing.” For almost a decade Tkarón:to was my home and the place where this project began while in graduate school. Born in the lands of the Wabanaki Confederacy and Mi’kmaq people (Charlottetown, PEI, Canada) and raised in New Delhi, India, my academic journey has now taken me across the settler borders of Canada and the United States. As a brahmin Indian hindu, I am an uninvited settler on Indian lands across Turtle Island, and my journey is embedded within colonial, racial, and caste entanglements. My positionality is structured by imperial geographies that led to different people across continents being colonized and labeled with a monolithic identity—that of an Indian. The names, roads, statues, and parks of places I have lived in have histories—not histories of European modernity, but histories of colonial expansion and racial capitalism across geographies, connecting the two kinds of Indians across South Asia and Turtle Island.

In the city of Tkarón:to, there are very few traces of these interweaved histories. For over six years I lived at the intersection of Dundas Street and Roncesvalles Avenue. The namesake of Dundas Street played a key role in the expansion of British colonialism in India, where for years he controlled the affairs of the East India Company and was a proponent of continuing enslavement.¹ Another colonizer named Roncesvalles Avenue after the Battle of Roncesvalles (in Spain), where England defeated Napoleon; he was also a proponent of British expansion in South Asia. In 2016, as I was preparing for my PhD defense, at the intersection of Dundas and Roncesvalles, in front of a Starbucks, a new urban garden, the “Dundas-Roncesvalles Peace Garden” was inaugurated. Hardly a garden, it has a selection of native trees and plants surrounded by a concrete enclosure and a mural painted by an Indigenous artist on a traffic signal box (touted as the first-ever Indigenous artwork on a signal box). According to the garden’s website: “The Dundas-Roncesvalles Peace Garden turns a barren lot of concrete . . . into a new public space of repose under native trees. Peace, not war, is celebrated here, through justice and reconciliation events, artistic and heritage expressions.” It was named Peace Garden to commemorate the “peace” following the War of 1812, where the British Empire and Indigenous nations won over the United States.

This stretch of Dundas was used as a trail by the retreating Anishinaabe soldiers, was upgraded into a road in 1813 by the York militia, and later used for the 1813 Battle of York. As a collaboration between the City of Toronto, the Roncesvalles Village community, and the Mississaugas of the New Credit First Nation, this garden is a unique, “permanent, joint, community arts project.” The opening ceremony celebrated “peace” bridged between Indigenous peoples and non-Indigenous peoples—the latter who are not settlers because of the implicit understanding that occupation was in the past. For the Mississaugas of New Credit people, being involved in the project was linked to the nation’s Moccasin Identifier project, intended to mark urban spaces with moccasin symbols to signify their territories. Yet the ceremony provides a stark example of how white settler colonial processes continue to normalize and invisibilize the colonization of Indigenous lands. For the local community partners, it is part of the bigger Peace Path project—to mark “peaceful” Canadian and American relations. Buzzwords like “reconciliation,” “peace,” and “apologies” are deployed to render colonialism to the past. Yet at the same time, their prominence is a constant reminder that colonialism never ended.

Other streets near my old home are named Indian Road, Indian Grove, Indian Road Crescent, Indian Valley Crescent, and Indian Trail, all named after the original inhabitants of the lands. These names are among the very few public markers



Dundas-Roncesvalles road sign. Photograph by Harshita Yalamarty. Courtesy Harshita Yalamarty.

of people who have lived here for centuries.² In the broader neighborhood, I was surrounded by Lansdowne Avenue, named after the Governor-General of Canada (1883–88) and Viceroy of India (1888–94); Dufferin Street, named after the Governor-General of Canada (1872–78) and Viceroy of India (1884–88); King Street and Queen Street, named after the British monarchy. Not far from home, in downtown, Queen’s Park—a green space behind Ontario’s legislature—has an equestrian statue of Edward VII, King of the United Kingdom and the British Dominions and Emperor of India (1901–10). The statue used to stand in Delhi and was given to the City of Toronto by the Indian government in 1969.³

Through academic transitions and moves since finishing my PhD, I’ve lived on Yaqui Drive on the base of the San Francisco peaks, homelands sacred to Sinagua, Pai, Hopi, Navajo, Apache peoples, and many other Indigenous communities (Flagstaff, Arizona). On Narragansett lands (Providence, Rhode Island), I lived a few minutes from India Park—the first port established in New England in 1680 to bring tea and spices from South Asia. On the foothills of

the Rocky Mountains on the lands of the Ute, Cheyenne, and Arapaho people (Denver, Colorado), I lived on Welton Street, named after one of the early white settlers in Denver. Currently, on the Cheyenne, Ute, Arapaho, Sioux, and Apache lands (Aurora, Colorado), I live next to Colfax Avenue; the namesake served as the vice president of the United States (1869–73) and was pivotal in Colorado attaining statehood. Following Indigenous protocols, the evocation of position on Indigenous lands is intentional to disrupt the settler states. By outlining these names, I seek to unmap colonial cartographies (Razack 2002)⁴ and illustrate the pernicious continuities across time and geographies. In other words, unmapping makes visible the histories that are made invisible through settler colonial logic.

By way of a short autobiographical introduction, I further sketch these connections through my parents' migration history. My father moved to Canada in the 1970s to pursue graduate studies. He moved from India for a higher education in North America; a testament of colonial and caste entanglements. In India, he was educated in the Indian university system, left behind by the same colonizers who established universities in Canada. That my father could complete his education in Canada, teach there briefly, and move back to India to teach there, shows how the migration of caste-privileged peoples is bound within racial capitalist and caste structures. My mother's migration journey, as a spouse invited by my father to Canada, speaks to the heteropatriarchal vectors of the Canadian immigration regime and brahminical patriarchy. My return to Canada after eighteen years of being in India without legal documents further marks my movements through geographies of colonialism and transnational caste mobility.

Ang Lee's 2012 film, *Life of Pi*, revolves around Piscine Molitor "Pi" Patel's journey from India to Canada, in which he survives a shipwreck while the rest of his family dies.⁵ In India, Pi's family runs a zoo. His father closes the zoo and intends to sell the animals and move to Winnipeg. While announcing his decision to the family, the father says: "We sail like Columbus." Pi is quick to point out the irony in the fact that Columbus intended to sail to India and not the Americas, so why would the family sail to Canada like Columbus? At the same time, the father's statement illustrates his aspirations to be Columbus in the Americas. It draws attention to the fact that for many Indians, like many other racialized communities, Canada and the United States are the lands of dreams and desires. These lands sell dreams of better, richer, and free(r) lives. The desire to be away from violence and oppression at home is the real factor behind migration for many, but for others, the desires are manifestations of their privileges.

How are Canadian and American dreams manufactured? The “American dream,” Inderpal Grewal explains, is a desire for consumption and liberal citizenship (2005, 5). The logic of American and Canadian dreams are separate yet also intertwined through neoliberal processes, with their respective melting pot and multicultural flavors. Much of the South Asian diaspora and migration studies situate the discussion of transnational migration within the interconnected vectors of colonialism and capitalism but remain silent on ongoing settler colonialism here on Turtle Island. Racialized migration to white settler states is a product, and often a necessity, of ongoing colonization of Indigenous lands. The erasure within South Asian diaspora studies is symptomatic of the broader settler colonial ideologies and speaks to the complicities of scholars and methodologies of “colonial unknowing.”⁶ Sisseton-Wahpeton Oyate scholar Kim Tallbear (2019) argues that American and Canadian dream-making is a settler colonial manifestation. Further, this dreaming “de-animates many humans, including Indigenous and Black people, by placing them below the Western and often male subject” Thus, dreams are manufactured by erasing past and ongoing colonial, racial, and gendered violence. Theorizing coloniality, Anibal Quijano (1999) contends that European colonial culture is made seductive by promising power and privileges to colonized societies. For over five hundred years, the “new world” has continued to disguise colonial and capitalist violence as desires. Settler colonialism, Beenash Jafri (2013) expands, is, after all, “a project of desire.” Instead of separating the affective from the material or reducing diasporic formations to either logic of desires or labor, in this book, I argue that the dreaming/desiring/laboring racialized bodies help us understand racial colonial capitalist processes in the making of white settler states. Within Indian diasporic contexts, caste capital and mobility also shape these desires toward Canadian and American dreams, further explored in the following chapters.

Indians on Indian Lands primarily asks what forms of relationalities, intimacies, complicities, and solidarities exist between Indigenous and diasporic dominant caste Indian communities within and beyond the settler colonial Canadian state.⁷ The book seeks to reframe transnational diasporic movements by exploring the making of first-generation dominant caste Indian diaspora in relation to ongoing Canadian settler colonial processes. It theorizes racial and colonial entanglements between Indigenous and diasporic Indian communities, Indian-Indian relationalities, and the complicities of Indian diaspora in the intertwined processes of settler colonialism, anti-Blackness, racial colonial capitalism, heteropatriarchy, and brahminism (hegemonic violent caste structures encoded within hinduism). This book adds to the growing scholarship on

Indigenous and Asian relationalities within Canadian and US settler states and offers a multi-sited exploration of contemporary Indigenous-Indian intimacies using mixed-methods interdisciplinary approaches. It is an exploration of what it means for dominant caste Indians, myself included, to be here on Turtle Island. Further, it also asks what it means to engage in decolonial ways of knowledge production and solidarity praxis, given our racialized caste-settler positionalities.

The book makes three broad interventions, specifically within the fields of Indian and South Asian diaspora studies, along with the disciplines of Asian Canadian/American studies, critical ethnic studies, settler colonial studies, feminist studies, and India studies. First, this book disrupts liberal frameworks of citizenship, immigration, and multiculturalism, to show how racialized immigration of Indians is complicit in the ongoing processes of Canadian settler colonialism and Indigenous dispossession. Within much of Indian and South Asian diaspora studies, such critiques are largely absent.⁸ I examine diasporic quotidian complicities, intimacies, relationalities, and solidarities between Indian and Indigenous peoples within settler extractive zones in British Columbia and Alberta, both across historical and contemporary temporal frameworks. Through interviews with Sikh retired workers in the lumber mills and canneries in BC between 1960 and the 1990s and “high-skilled” dominant caste Indian hindus working in the tar sands in Alberta currently, I illustrate everyday modalities of racial colonial capitalism in the making of these uneven, messy, and complex “material intimacies.” I demonstrate how notions of “model minority” and “steady workers” are deployed by diasporic Indians by rendering the Indigenous and Black Others as “unmodel.” Further, I engage with interracial romantic and sexual intimacies, what I call “colonial intimacies,” between the two communities through literature. I theorize relationships between differently racialized and colonized peoples as colonial intimacies to foreground settler colonial contexts that allow for such intimacies to form. Analyzing colonial intimacies allows for a fuller engagement with gender, sexual, and racial formations in settler colonial states, and the framework illustrates the workings of coloniality of racial/sexual power. Given the long histories of regulating sexuality and intimacies, I argue that these intimacies lie in a continuum of possibilities and impossibilities between reproducing violent structures of oppression and fostering decolonial love, erotics, and relationalities.

Second, I add the analytic of caste to illustrate the making of *casted-settler* in white settler states. The book presents a theory of transnational intersections of settler colonialism and brahminism to argue that brahmin and dominant caste Indian complicities are shaped through their caste positionalities, capital, and

mobility. Until recently, anti-caste and anti-brahminism analytics remained largely unexplored within South Asian diaspora studies.⁹ These frameworks, as I demonstrate in the following chapters, radically dismantle any monolithic idea of the “Indian” as it functions transnationally across empires, thereby bringing together anti-brahminism and anti-settler colonialism frameworks to theorize Indian diasporic formations on Turtle Island. First, I offer critiques of Indian-centric postcolonial theoretical and transnational feminist frameworks as a form of complicities of brahmin and dominant caste Indian diasporic scholars within processes of brahminism and settler colonialism. To do so, I engage with anti-brahminical critiques that often do not travel within Canadian and American academia, and offer grammar to scholars not familiar with how brahminism shapes knowledge production in India and the Indian diaspora. Second, I draw upon interviews in tar sands to demonstrate the formation of the casted-settler subjectivities in Alberta. Third, I illustrate how caste is foundational to diasporic hindu nationalist politics and the transnational settler colonial projects of India, Canada, and the United States.

Lastly, the book offers a framework to theorize solidarities between racialized and Indigenous communities as a continuum of possibilities and impossibilities. More specifically, I illustrate the limits of solidarities by people who embody brahmin and dominant caste diasporic subjectivities. I juxtapose these limits with quotidian intimacies and relations by other South Asians; with Indigenous peoples. These other solidarities contest imperial powers, racial and caste hierarchies, and Indigenous dispossession. *Indians on Indian Lands* oscillates between possibilities and impossibilities of other solidarities and futures.¹⁰

In what follows, I offer the overarching theoretical frameworks, methodological musings, and an overview of the book. In the first section, drawing from Indigenous studies, Asian Canadian/American studies, and critical ethnic studies, I theorize colonial entanglements, complicities, and solidarities in the making of the white settler states, and the varying relationalities between Indigenous, Black, and other racialized communities. I then offer a methodological discussion on research gaps, silences, and traces. Finally, I provide a brief outline of the following chapters.

ENTANGLEMENTS, COMPLICITIES, SOLIDARITIES

Chickasaw scholar Jodi A. Byrd offers a theoretical framework to understand settler colonialism as a cacophony of “contradictorily hegemonic and horizontal struggles” between asymmetrically colonized and racialized communities (2011, 53). Byrd cautions that even as processes of racialization and colonization work

simultaneously, scholars should not conflate the two. It is through the erasure of sovereignty that Indigenous peoples are rendered as another racial/ethnic minority within the settler states.¹¹ Elaborating on colonial entanglements, Lisa Lowe argues that Indigenous expropriation, African enslavement, and other racial dispossessions “are imbricated processes, not sequential events; they are ongoing and continuous in our contemporary moment” (2015, 7). She explains these differentials by theorizing “intimacies of four continents” between the Americas, Africa, Asia, and Europe.¹² In *Indians on Indian Lands*, by focusing on pernicious continuities, I invert “the intimacies of four continents” to examine how one place, Canada, moves through racial colonial capitalist processes.¹³ By focusing on the Canadian settler state, this book explores how colonial intimacies are formed between Indigenous and diasporic Indians.

The binaries of colonizer/colonized, Native/non-Native, and white/non-white gloss over the contradictory and unanticipated effects of intimacies produced by racial colonial capitalist processes, especially pertaining to asymmetrical hierarchies between racialized and colonized communities. Colonial processes produced a range of subjects that complicate and sometimes subvert racial distinctions. Albert Memmi elaborates on this inbetweenness: “The lesser privileges of the small colonizer, even the smallest, are very numerous. Every act of his daily life places him in a relationship with the colonized” (2003 [1974]). I draw from Memmi to illustrate the multiplicities of hierarchies formed within white settler colonial contexts. Non-Indigenous and non-Black racialized communities on colonized lands are often in this inbetweenness in the everyday of settler colonialism. Pertinent to this book, diasporic dominant caste Indians come from histories of British colonialism, where Thomas B. Macaulay, a colonial officer (1834–38) and the author of *Minute on Indian Education* (1835), sought to create a class of “brown sahibs” who were brown in color but English in taste, culture, and education.¹⁴ By educating elite brahmin and dominant caste Indians, Macaulay intended for these brown sahibs to help the British better govern their colonies. Shefali Chandra adds on this history: “A range of non-white actors deployed whiteness to cement a range of social inequities beyond the purview of colonizer/colonized, white/non-white, Europe/Other” (2011, 132–133). So while in British India an elite class of brown sahibs was produced, in Canada the same colonizers sought to “kill the Indian in the child” through residential schools. These pernicious continuities illustrate the interlocking yet uneven materialities of colonialism and point to some diasporic Indians who come from this class of brown sahibs, through colonial and postcolonial education systems, and are posited as better Canadians than the Indian Others.

To exemplify the asymmetrical modalities of racial inbetweenness, *Indians on Indian Lands* is in conversation with Indigenous and Asian diasporic scholars working across and against the Canadian and US settler colonial projects. While there are many differences between Canadian and US settler projects, like varying technologies of land appropriation, Indigenous dispossession, legal and constitutional tools, regulation of Indigeneity, and Indigenous governance models, without conflating the two states and erasing their specificities, in this book I draw from Native American, Indigenous, and settler colonial studies from both contexts to map the trans-colonial and transborder continuities between the two projects. Similarly, Asian migration across the two settler states is uneven yet deeply intertwined in their histories of Asian exclusion, exploitation of Asian labor, contemporary vectors of “model minority” constructs, anti-Asian racism, anti-Muslim racism, xenophobia, and border imperialism.¹⁵ There is a growing body of scholarship theorizing the complicities of variously positioned Asian communities across the two settler states. This scholarship has largely emerged from provocations by Indigenous scholars asking scholars to recognize their positionalities and responsibilities as non-Indigenous peoples *settled* upon Indigenous lands. Writing about the US occupation of Hawai‘i, Kānaka Maoli scholar Haunani-Kay Trask argued that Asians are “settlers of color” who “claim Hawai‘i as their own, denying indigenous history, their long collaboration in our continued dispossession and the benefits there from” (2000, 2). Trask acknowledged that these claims to Hawai‘i are often made in the face of xenophobic anti-Asian racism. However, she contended that for the Kānaka Maoli peoples, Asian settlement is “the latest elaboration of foreign hegemony.” Building on Trask, Jonathan Okamura and Candace Fujikane’s (2008) conceptualization of Asian settler colonialism has provided a pertinent framework to theorize the role of Asian communities within Hawai‘i. Fujikane (2008) critiques Asian investment in American democracy and multiculturalism and calls for an epistemological shift to center Indigenous resistance to the US occupation.

Critiquing Canadian settler-multicultural formation, Bonita Lawrence and Ena Dua argue that despite varying histories of migration people of color are “settlers of color” as they “live on land that is appropriated and contested, where Aboriginal peoples are denied nationhood and access to their own lands” (2005, 134). Racialized communities are implicated through a wide spectrum of engagement with the state: from liberal/multicultural claims of belonging to anti-racist and anti-border activism. All these forms of racial belonging to the state, they contend, highlight colonial relation with Indigenous peoples. In a similar manner, writing about the United States, Eve Tuck (Unangaʻx) and

K. Wayne Yang also hold that people of color are settlers as “certain minorities can at times become model and quasi-assimilable” (2012, 18). They posit that some racialized people aspire to “brown settler” status even if they cannot claim whiteness.¹⁶ The term “settler of color” is used to name complicities and analyze hierarchical relations between Indigenous peoples and other colonized and racialized peoples. The terms also allow for non-Indigenous communities of color to reimagine their investments to the settler state and possibly align themselves with Indigenous decolonization. The term, however, has its limitations. Primarily, the term has been critiqued by Black scholars for its inability to recognize how anti-Blackness operates and shapes Black subjectivities in the United States and Canada (I explore these critiques below).¹⁷ While the push from many scholars has been to reject the term,¹⁸ I argue it is pertinent to refuse the homogenization of all people of color as settlers. Instead, it should be seen as a tool in exploring varying uneven positionalities and complicities to foster relational solidarity praxis.¹⁹

Theorizations of anti-Blackness remain a critical point of contention in these conversations. The entangled complexities between these differing racial and colonial projects point to the fact that Blackness is not reducible to settlerness, and anti-Blackness works as a distinct structure of violence and not solely as a function of settler colonialism. Scholars show how the Canadian state continues to imagine its past and present without Blackness, Blackness as always located elsewhere, Blackness as “absented presence” (Walcott 1997). Katherine McKittrick (2006) contends that the Canadian state obliterates its own complicities and participation in the transatlantic enslavement and the histories of early Black communities in Canada and posits itself as a historical refuge to enslaved people from the United States, or contemporarily as the multicultural land of opportunities to new Afro-Caribbean and African immigrants. Black communities are always non-Canadian, she adds, “always other, always elsewhere, recent, unfamiliar, and impossible” (99). Like the variations in settler colonial processes across Canada and the United States, the logic of anti-Blackness is distinct across the two states, given the varying histories of enslavement and contemporary formations of anti-Blackness, yet they are also contiguous. Like transborder critiques of settler colonialism and regimes of Asian migration, it is pertinent to theorize the congruences and intersections of anti-Blackness across the borders. It is also critical to pay attention to the “afterlife of slavery” (Hartman 2007), and the continued dehumanization of Black people.

Tiffany L. King theorizes the intertwined vectors of slavery and genocide as without edges: “Each form of violence has its own way of contaminating, haunt-

ing, touching, caressing, and whispering to the other” (2019, x). Tuck and Yang (2012) argue that settler colonialism is built upon the triad of settler-native-slave,²⁰ where the settler/plantation owner is always positioned as superior to Indigenous and Black Others. Other racialized communities, they add, become part of this triad. Critiques of Indigenous and settler colonial studies raised by Black scholars, particularly from Afropessimist perspectives, are crucial here.²¹ The totality and abjection of Black suffering as theorized within the Afropessimist framework, however, make another set of absolute claims. The totalizing motives behind these varying frameworks are rooted, Justin Leroy (2016) observes, in the ways Black and Indigenous studies have largely come up in isolation to each other.²² For J. Kēhaulani Kauanui (Kānaka Maoli), the absolutism is not only ahistorical, given how racialization is a continuous process, but it also hinders “the possibility for coalitional politics” (2017, 263). Logics of Blackness and Indigeneity are not mutually exclusive; rather, anti-Blackness works in tandem with settler colonialism to dispossess both Indigenous and Black peoples. Moreover, Kyle Mays’s (2021) theorization of Black Indigeneity to underscore the Indigeneity of enslaved Africans, exposes the intersections of settler colonialism and anti-Blackness. Black liberation is inherently connected to Indigenous decolonization, and vice versa. In the following chapters, I explore the complicities of Indian diasporic communities in both these processes. While the primary focus of *Indians on Indian Lands* is unmapping settler colonial processes in the making of dominant-caste Indian diasporas in Canada, each chapter makes visible the intersections of anti-Blackness with settler colonialism in exploring transnational intersections of race, caste, and Indigeneity (Chapters 1 and 3), model minority constructs (Chapter 2), and forging of colonial intimacies (Chapter 4).

When I first started framing this project as a graduate student, I was invested in proving that Indian communities are settlers on Indigenous lands. I sought to theorize how complicity looks within settler colonialism by asking direct questions like: What is your role on Indigenous lands? What do you know about Native people? Are you a settler? However, the assumptions behind these questions were false on two counts: One, settler colonialism is neither unequivocal nor explicit in its functioning, and two, settler colonialism cannot be studied in isolation. Settler colonialism must be engaged with its entanglements, contradictions, and continuities. Consequently, complicity is neither explicit nor unambiguous, and neither can it be theorized in isolation. Candace Fujikane reminds us: “Being a settler ally means an opposition to all forms of oppression mobilized by the occupying or settler state” (2021, 14). Complicity in one structure does not occlude complicities in other structures of power: in other

words, complicities are always enabled by, and enable other, structures of complicities. To theorize complicities thus requires a “transnational, intersectional, relational, genealogical, and conjunctural” approach (Medak-Saltzman and Tiongson Jr. 2015, 5). Which is why this project explores the ways complicities within settler colonialism are co-produced through the intertwined processes of racial colonial capitalism, anti-Blackness, brahminism, and heteropatriarchy.

The core argument of the book is simple and straightforward: dominant caste Indian diasporic communities on Turtle Island are complicit in ongoing processes of settler colonialism. To those versed in the fields of Indigenous studies, settler colonial studies, and critical ethnic studies, this is not a unique argument. Neither is this proposition new for activists, organizers, and artists immersed in struggles for collective liberation. What this book offers is the in-depth interrogation of what quotidian complicity looks like. Theorizing complicity requires going beyond what is normative or visible. The uneven ways complicity is shaped by race, caste, class, gender, sexuality, and religion, calls for a granular analysis of the encounters and proximities between communities. It seeks a methodological approach that exposes hegemonic power relations often deemed unworthy of engagement within Indian diaspora studies, namely: disruption of belonging to the settler state; how caste, class, gender, and sexuality shape the diasporic community; caste and knowledge production; and interracial desires, intimacies, and relations. The following chapters explore these different modalities of complicities. They illuminate the ways Indians enact and reproduce, wittingly or unwittingly, the logics of the settler state.

Investigation of complicities is not a confession of privilege. Neither is the book invested in moral or political blaming and shaming individuals. Instead, theorizing complicities allows us to understand how uneven access to power positions some racialized communities as colluders with the state. Moreover, exposing complicities illuminates other relationalities, solidarities, and possibilities. This interrogation makes visible the multitudinous ways racialized diasporas align, and possibly un-align, themselves with the settler project. Accordingly, going beyond gestures and acknowledgments, the book unravels how power operates asymmetrically in a settler society. It also opens space for the abundant contestations against colonial powers. While complicity cannot be opted out of, at the same time, complicity and solidarity are not binaries. Rather, they exist in a continuum where the possibilities of solidarity are not erased due to complicity; complicity, however, makes some solidarities fraught, messy, and dubious. Indeed, the two can co-exist as illustrated by examples specifically discussed in the Conclusion. Further, complicities and solidarities morph and evolve. The primary focus of *Indians on Indian Lands* is to explore

these messy and fluid relationalities as they are lived, negotiated, and reproduced. Yet, simultaneously, the book seeks to make other solidarities possible. To be in ethical and reciprocal relationships with Indigenous peoples, for non-Indigenous racialized people requires, as Dean Saranillio (2018, xix) writes, “bolstering Native movements for deoccupation.” This book is a reminder for racialized communities, especially the ones I belong to as a queer, trans, non-binary brahmin Indian hindu, to unsettle *our* investments to the settler states,²³ refuse *our* participation within the settler states,²⁴ and reimagine *our* presence on Indigenous lands as accomplices toward relational and decolonial futures.²⁵ In other words, echoing Santhosh Chandrashekar (2018, 78), “hope we can arrive at a better understanding of how we have been coopted to cloud out indigeneity, whether we participate in it willingly or not.”

GAPS, ABSENCES, TRACES: METHODOLOGICAL NOTES

In Fall 2020, I was on research leave and was supposed to do further fieldwork in Canada to finish this manuscript. But like other aspects of life, COVID-19 disrupted my research plans. During the first year of the pandemic, I sat with the uncertainty of the pandemic, no ways of being in the field, and the impending manuscript deadline. During this time, the epistemological demands of the settler academy became more visible to me. My plans were to visit and conduct further research with Haida, Tsimshian, Nisga’a, Haisla, Gitxsan, and Wet’suwet’en communities in and around Prince Rupert, BC, and Cree, Dene, and Métis people in and around Fort McMurray, Alberta. This research would have added to my previous work with diasporic Indians who had lived and worked in northern British Columbia in the 1960s-1990s and those who currently live and work in northern Alberta. I had envisioned this new research to *center* Indigenous voices in the book, in order to conceptualize Indigenous and diasporic Indian intimacies with more rigor. Throughout the duration of this project, from the dissertation proposal stage to the book in your hands or electronic device, the imperative methodological and political question that I have continued to ask myself is: how do I ethically and responsibly center Indigenous voices?

At the dissertation fieldwork stage, when I had conducted formal interviews with diasporic Indians, I engaged in many informal conversations with Indigenous elders, activists, and scholars. However, these conversations did not make it in the dissertation. This was a conscious choice I made for the following two reasons: The first factor was the Indigenous research ethics protocols at my alma mater. Although the ethics guidelines are a recognition of epistemic

violence committed by the academy on Indigenous nations and people, they place unreasonable demands upon Indigenous communities. What the academy demands is a “collaboration” with Indigenous communities; according to “Guidelines for Research Involving Aboriginal/Indigenous Peoples” (2012, 1–2) at my alma mater, York University:

Researchers conducting research where the research is likely to affect the welfare of an Aboriginal/Indigenous Peoples community, or communities, to which prospective participants belong, researchers shall seek engagement with the relevant community. The nature and extent of community engagement in a project shall be determined jointly by the researcher and the relevant community.

While in theory this is a crucial principle, given centuries of complicities of settler institutions, for me it became a deterrent because it demanded my imposition on Indigenous communities, that is *to ask them to make my research their priority*. University’s ethics inhibited my own ethics to foster reciprocal relationality with Indigenous communities. Second, there was a barrier in terms of contact, logistics, and colonial geographies. As a graduate student with minimal funding support, and no car or driver’s license, research with Indigenous communities who did not reside in urban areas was out of the question. Spatial segregation is indeed a function of colonialism. For instance, in Fort McMurray, most Native communities live outside urban spaces that were inaccessible by public transit. In British Columbia, diasporic Indians from northern British Columbia whom I interviewed had settled in Vancouver post-retirement, while much fewer northern Native people had the financial mobility to migrate south. Due to these reasons, I decided to wait to go back to the field when I had more institutional support. The US institutions, for the most part, on the other hand, do not have specific guidelines for Indigenous research. In fact, Indigenous research is not even considered historically or potentially harmful by many settler institutions. As problematic as that is, I was determined to traverse the lack of protocols for my project in ways where I could be ethical to Indigenous communities on their terms and not on institutional standards.²⁶ However, navigating precarity in the academy and heavy teaching loads with no research support in R2 and R3 institutions delayed my plans.²⁷ Two academic positions later, I ended up at my current position at an R1 institution, which has given me significantly more access to resources and funds.²⁸

Asymmetrical Indigenous research protocols, access to funding, spatial isolation of Indigenous communities, and pandemic-related disruption are all part of the same spectrum that organizes research and knowledge production in the settler academy. I have come to realize that the ways “gaps” are articulated and the methods of overcoming these “gaps” are romanticized colonial fabrications.

Perceiving gaps as research failures means that I can go to the field, whenever institutional support and non-pandemic accessibility are aligned next in my career, to fill in the gaps. I posit that gaps and overcoming gaps are both binary products of coloniality/modernity which reproduce ideas of whole, universal, and readily available truths (Quijano 1999; Wynter 2003). Undoing coloniality would require much more than just filling the gaps or writing this self-reflexive methodological piece. This narrative may even appear to be a cop-out for the limitations of the project; however, I argue that finding the truth about the lived intimacies between Indians and other Indians is always going to be an incomplete academic project. The academy is invested in foreclosing these intimacies, especially as they exist outside of it.

Lisa Lowe (2015) asks why the intimacies formed among differently racialized and colonized people have been forgotten, silenced, or obscured. She contends that forgetting is an essential component of liberal ideological formations; forgetting effaces the violence that produces liberalism itself. Arbitrary categorizations of race and ethnicity, teleological markers of progress and development, and geopolitical divisions of west/east are all, Lowe writes, “*traces of liberal forgetting*” (39, emphasis in original). Tracking these traces offers pertinent methodological approaches to the study of modalities of settler colonialism. Traces make visible the multitude forms of power that are not always readily visible. Arguing against sociological quantitative and qualitative methodologies invested in the truth of the empirical and evidence, Macarena Gómez-Barris and Herman Gray (2010, 4) propose a “sociology of the trace” that can blur the lines between data that can be observed and those that cannot be readily observed. They elaborate:

We are interested in the archives of traces and inscriptions, things often absent from the purview of disciplinary knowledge, not simply because we do not have the tools to see them but because imprints of power do not easily slide into proscriptive categories.

They suggest studying the traces, first, by challenging the constitution of social facts as evidence, instead of engaging with their historical and social specificities, and second, by understanding all forms of socio-cultural power (5–6). Refusing the dominance of evidence and the empirical as forms of colonial governmentality, they propose methodologies that center embodied subjectivities, imaginations, and creativity. Saidiya Hartman (2008, 13), writing about the absences in the archives of slavery, similarly reminds us: “The necessity of trying to represent what we cannot, rather than leading to pessimism or despair must be embraced as the impossibility that conditions our knowledge of the past and animates our desire for a liberated future.” In

hopes of liberated futures, I deploy trace as a methodology—a methodology that traces power within uneven colonial processes to unravel what has been made silent, erased, and absent.

Jodi A. Byrd (2011, xvii–xviii) argues that “traces of Indianness” unmap processes of power and colonialism in the making and maintaining of the US settler empire, and “yet because they are traces, they have often remained deactivated as a point of critical inquiry.” The figure of the Indian shapes white settler colonialisms, even as the Indian is “nowhere and everywhere within the ontological premises” (xix). Thus, following traces of Indigeneity reveal everyday logic of power within the settler states. Further, these traces shape the presence of racialized diasporas on colonized lands. By locating these “traces of Indianness” within Indian diasporas, in the following chapters, I demonstrate that the presence of diasporic Indians on Indian lands is structured through original and ongoing processes of colonialism, but also their racialized subjectivities are constructed vis-à-vis the presence, or sometimes absence, of the *Other* Indian. Instead of locating these relationalities, intimacies, and complicities solely in the archives, I use trace as a methodology to offer “new ways of both mining and undermining the evidence of the archive” (Arondekar 2009, 3). The archives, broadly defined, are not empty but full of traces, traces that narrate stories of themselves. Inversely, these stories enable us to trace what is made absent, invisible, and forgotten. The stories in this book are primarily woven through interviews and conversations to provide social texture to the traces found or not found in the archives. The following chapters foreground stories that illuminate traces in stories and stories in traces, and make visible colonial intimacies, complicities, and other solidarities.

OVERVIEW OF THE BOOK

Following Māori scholar Linda T. Smith’s (1994, 34) call for “site by site” review to transform colonized views of histories, I look at racialized subjectivities, labor, and complicities in Canadian extractive zones. I draw from Macarena Gómez-Barris’s (2017, xvi) definition of extractive zones as “colonial paradigm, worldview, and technologies that mark out regions of ‘high diversity’ in order to reduce life to capitalist resource conversion.” Further, these zones are, what Sarah Hunt (Kwakwaka’wakw) calls, colonialscares, spaces that normalize the relations of hierarchy, domination, and dehumanization as integral to colonialism (2014, 7). Specifically, the book theorizes dominant caste Indian immigrant labor in resource extraction industries, lumber mills, and canneries in unceded lands of British Columbia in the 1960s–1990s and the tar sands in Treaty 6 lands

of Alberta currently. The book examines these sites as simultaneous spaces of Indigenous dispossession, spaces of racialized-classed-gendered-casted labor formations, and spaces that continue to fuel the climate crises. Interweaving theory, interviews and conversations, ethnography, cultural and literary analysis, archival research,²⁹ analysis of recent events, and secondary literature, the book forms the archive of Indigenous and Indian spatial and affective intimacies that exist within and across the afterlives of imperialism.

A multi-method and interdisciplinary approach allows us to understand quotidian lived experiences of diasporic communities, which cannot be solely captured using one method or one disciplinary approach. To study the intersections of race, caste, and Indigeneity, I illustrate how interviews, archives, ethnography, and literature all offer varying insights into the making of the settler state. They all trace the absences, silences, and erasures, which otherwise are not readily visible. This multi-sited, multi-method, interdisciplinary approach, thereby, allows me to theorize the interwoven and simultaneous intimacies and complicities of dominant caste Indian diasporic communities in processes of settler colonialism, anti-Blackness, racial colonial capitalism, brahminism, hindu nationalism, and heteropatriarchy.

Indians on Indian Lands primarily theorizes the lives and complicities of dominant caste first-generation Indians within the Canadian settler state. Given that Indians constitute one of the largest racialized immigrant communities in Canada, it is imperative to study Indian diasporic formation in Canada, paying specific attention to the logic of settler colonialism. Between 2013 to 2023, Indian immigration to Canada tripled in numbers, an increase of 260 percent; making Indians the largest incoming immigrant community (Anderson 2023). According to Statistics Canada (2022), Indians make up 1.4 million, or 3.7 percent, of the total population.³⁰ In 2022 alone, around 120,000 Indians became permanent residents of Canada (Anderson 2023).³¹ While Indians have been immigrating to Canada for over a century, the recent escalation in numbers is due to Canada specifically targeting “high-skilled” workers for immigration through programs³² like the Express Entry program (2015),³³ Global Skills Strategy (2017),³⁴ and Economic Mobility Pathways Pilot (2018)³⁵ (see detailed discussion of Canadian immigration policies in Chapter 2). Since the pandemic, Canada has announced to accept more “high-skilled” migrants and create easier pathways for immigration and integration for them. Yasmeen Abu-Laban et al. (2022, 106) note that “high-skilled” immigrants are deemed desirable as they embody neoliberal ethics the best. Moreover, in this book, I demonstrate that “high-skilled” immigrants are rendered as the more desirable “model minority” due to their investments in the settler state. Given the underpinnings of

the racial-settler-neoliberal-economy, Indian migration illustrates the transnational calculus of myriad colonial, capitalist, racial, gendered, and caste processes.

First-generation communities are an important site of analysis to understand how they negotiate, survive, reproduce, and resist the racial-colonial-gendered logic that shapes their citizenship claims and belonging to the settler state. All respondents in Fort McMurray, Vancouver, and Surrey were first-generation migrants from different parts of India, with varying caste, religious, linguistic, regional, class, and gender positionalities. First-generation Indian immigrants also hold on to their national, regional, religious, linguistic, and caste identities much more than succeeding generations and often do not necessarily see themselves as racialized or as a person of color. While some Fort McMurray interlocutors moved to Canada with their parents, and thus strictly not first-generation, their migration and experiences are more closely aligned to those of first-generation Indians than succeeding generations. My respondents were unknown to me prior to being in the field. In Vancouver and Surrey, I spoke to Sikh immigrants who had moved to Canada in the 1960s–1970s from different rural parts of Punjab, a northwestern state in India. During the summers of 2013 and 2014, I spoke to Punjabi men who worked in sawmills and Punjabi women who worked in fish canneries.³⁶ Everyone I spoke to has now retired and “settled” in British Columbia’s Lower Mainland. I reached out to most of my respondents through elders in the community—writers, activists, and academic communities.³⁷ These elders connected me with different respondents. I conducted the interviews in a combination of Punjabi, Hindi, and English, while my respondents were most comfortable in Punjabi. Everyone I spoke to in Vancouver and Surrey is a naturalized Canadian citizen, *jat* Sikh (dominant caste), and in a heterosexual (presumedly endogamic) marriage. Men mostly came with visitor status and women mostly came as sponsored partners.³⁸ The respondents had varying formal education levels. Some respondents possessed land back home and some did not.

In the summer of 2013, I interviewed Indian men engineers working from middle to upper middle levels in the oil companies. In addition, I spoke to Indian women, all married to engineers: one was an engineer, two were employed in human resources departments, one was a bank worker, and one ran a daycare out of her home. I met these respondents through a friend living in Fort McMurray. These respondents are among the minority of skilled white-collar workers in “Fort McMoneys”—who are able to afford a stable work routine and still make, in their words, “great money.” All the respondents were highly educated and skilled, upwardly mobile, dominant caste Indian Hindus, and in heterosexual (presumedly endogamic) marriages. They all came from different urban centers

in India. All interviews were conducted in English, but my participants spoke a range of languages including Gujarati, Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, and Punjabi. Some had moved to Canada as youth with their families, while some moved later for education, and others later in their careers. At the time of the interviews, respondents had been in town for an average of five to six years (a minimum of three years and maximum of thirteen years). All my respondents were either naturalized Canadian citizens or permanent residents. There are stark variances in the experiences of the communities in Vancouver and Fort McMurray based on identities, locations, migration patterns, temporal differences, and a sense of relationality with Indigenous people; I expand on these differences in Chapters 2 and 3.

To juxtapose accounts of first-generation immigrants, I interviewed four Tkarón:to-based queer, femme, and nonbinary “South Asian” dreamers who through their activism, art, and work, illustrate other relationalities and solidarities with Indigenous peoples. I call them dreamers because they give us visions for other worlds through their quotidian praxis. They all have asymmetrical, layered, and multiple migration histories and relations with what is called South Asia, and have varying gender, sexual, ethnic, national, religious, caste, class, and linguistic identities and differing abilities. Some do not use the marker of “South Asian,”³⁹ and through their work problematize the hegemonic monolith. These dreamers, Kavita Bissoondial, Rinchen Dolma, Mita Hans, and Maneesa Sotheeswaran, are part of my community in Tkarón:to. The conversations with them offer varying examples of these embodied subjectivities illuminating everyday praxis of “emergent relationalities” (Malaver 2023). These interviews were conducted via Zoom and email in 2021.

Studying South Asian diasporic communities across British Columbia, Alberta, and Ontario, within the time periods of 1970–1990s, 2000–2010s, and 2010–2020s, respectively, the book offers a temporal-spatial framework to privilege the “local” within the Canadian settler project. The multiple geographies and time periods enable the theorization of uneven and messy complicities, intimacies, and solidarities, and illustrate the varied logic of power in localized space and time. They show differing migration patterns, diasporic formations, relationalities with Indigenous peoples, belonging to the settler state, and diversity within the South Asian diaspora. BC and Alberta illuminate how extraction industries rely on asymmetrical racialized labor regimes, which shape the demands for working-class or “high-skilled” labor in settler extractive zones. By juxtaposing the two time periods and geographies, I show how the changing needs of the settler economy have shaped these Indian immigrant communities varying through the vectors of class, caste, religion, education, and gender. Yet, at the same time, the settler state has continued to exploit these vectors to

extract the labor it requires from immigrants. The two sites, thus, make visible the logic of a larger Indian presence in these industries across different time periods. Finally, the inclusion of Tkarón:to-based dreamers in the book offers other praxes of non-belonging to the settler state. Tkarón:to as a multicultural urban hub of Canada *can* (at times) allow for other relationalities that disrupt the hegemonic logic of colonial racial capitalism.

In Chapter 1, I offer a theoretical overview to understand brahminism in India and the Indian diaspora. I offer a detailed discussion of brahminical state violence in India, the “coloniality of brahminical supremacy” (Upadhyay and Bakshi 2020), to unravel the casted logic of dominant caste Indian hindu migration to Turtle Island as well to also illustrate the shortcomings of Indian-centric theoretical frameworks, like postcolonial theory and transnational feminisms in their engagement with caste and settler colonialisms, here and there. This chapter seeks to highlight anti-brahminical critiques that often do not circulate within American and Canadian academia, especially within disciplines like critical ethnic studies, Asian Canadian and American studies, Indigenous and Native American studies, American studies, and feminist studies. In the first section, I provide a primer to understand violence based on caste, Indigeneity, race, ethnicity, and religion in postcolonial India (which must be understood as a colonizing nation itself). Building on this discussion, in the following section I discuss how Indian postcolonial and transnational feminists in the settler academy have limitedly engaged with processes of transnational brahminism and settler colonialism. I extend anti-caste analytics to demonstrate how their conceptualizations of settler colonialism, or lack thereof, need to be understood by unpacking casted subjectivities and complicities.

Chapter 2 contrasts high-skilled Indian professionals in the tar sands contemporarily with working-class Punjabi and Sikh retired workers in the lumber mills and cannery industries in British Columbia between 1960s-1990s. Drawing upon interviews, I trace how Indians, across these differing extractive zones, position themselves as the “model” and “steady” workers and render Indigenous peoples as the “unmodel” Others. This Othering happens in relation to processes of anti-Blackness as well. The chapter argues that while race, gender, and class may structurally marginalize the labor of diasporic Indians in these different industries, their labor remains complicit, wittingly or unwittingly, in settler colonial processes. This chapter also highlights the spatial and material intimacies that working-class jobs allowed between Indigenous and Indian workers in BC, as compared to the lack of such intimacies in Alberta.

Chapter 3 builds on the previous two chapters to bring together an anti-caste analysis with anti-settler colonial critiques to illustrate the intersections of race, caste, and Indigeneity. It argues that while caste may not be an obvious factor in

the analysis of settler colonialism, any comprehensive understanding of Indian diasporas is incomplete without critiques of brahminism. Drawing upon my fieldwork in Fort McMurray, I argue that for dominant caste Indian Hindus the Indigenous Other is constructed through colonial and caste processes that allow for the dominant caste Indian-self to recognize the latter as the caste Other. The subsequent discussion shifts the focus to the United States to illustrate the different ways *hindutva* (right-wing Hindu nationalism) is an extension of brahminism, are organizing in the diaspora and how notions of Indigeneity are often invoked by these players drawing upon Indigenous frameworks from Turtle Island. In this chapter, I bring together caste and settler colonial technologies from Canada, the United States, and India to foreground the fact that brahminism is a transnational project. It is critical to understand how caste supremacy functions in tandem with other global projects of settler colonialism, anti-Muslim racism, white supremacy, fascism, and neoliberalism. While Chapter 1 focused on progressive diasporic scholars, this chapter engages with processes of right-wing knowledge production.

In juxtaposition to Chapter 2's focus on material intimacies, in Chapter 4 I focus on sexual/romantic interracial intimacies between Indigenous peoples and Indians, what I term "colonial intimacies," by weaving two short stories together: Cree writer Tomson Highway's short story "The Lover Snake" (2013) and Punjabi writer Sadhu Binning's short story "Eyes in the Dark" (2014). Colonial intimacies engage with gender, sexual, and racial formations in settler colonial states, to theorize the coloniality of racial/sexual power. Analytics of colonial intimacies does not seek to deny agency and desire, rather it highlights how differently colonized and racialized bodies encounter each other within the white settler state, and how the trajectories of these intimacies are scripted through settler colonial logic—though not necessarily in totality of any form. These intimacies lie in a continuum of impossibilities and possibilities, between reproduction and resistance.

In the Conclusion, I offer musings from Tkaron:to-based dreamers who offer quotidian examples of other relationalities, solidarities, and futures. These dreamers generously gift us examples of everyday praxis of ethical and reciprocal relationality. I end the book with the hope that these embodied solidarities for impossible futures stay with the readers more than the caste-settler pessimism which is the dominant narrative in the book. This pessimism is both the function of my caste positionality as well as my academic training. To counter the pessimism, I offer meditations from the dreamers as a toolkit for other futures.

